

6 Play Activities to Build Confidence with Uncertainty



Mystery Movement Dice



What's in the Bag?



Silly Rule Change Game



Mystery Box Build



Surprise Story Path



Almost Wrong Obstacles

Weekly Planner



HULA HOOP ACTIVITIES

MYSTERY MOVEMENT

DICE

Skill focus: Flexible thinking, anticipation, body confidence, emotional regulation

Materials: A large dice, picture cards or movement cards.

Setup: Place movement cards in a basket, such as jump, crawl, spin, stretch, stomp, tiptoe or freeze.

Activity: Children roll the dice, then pick a mystery movement card to discover what action they will do. The educator can add playful suspense by saying, "I wonder what your body will get to try next?" Start with familiar movements before adding sillier or less expected ones. This helps children experience surprise while still feeling safe and supported.



WHAT'S IN THE BAG?

Skill focus: Curiosity, sensory confidence, prediction, flexible thinking

Materials: A fabric bag and safe objects such as a feather, pinecone, scarf, block, spoon, small toy or soft ball.

Setup: Place one object inside the bag without showing the children.

Activity: Children take turns feeling the object inside the bag and guessing what it might be before it is revealed. They can describe what they notice: "It feels soft," "It has bumps," or "It is round." The reveal becomes a small moment of safe uncertainty, helping children practise not knowing, wondering, guessing and then finding out.



SILLY RULE CHANGE

GAME

Skill focus: Cognitive flexibility, inhibition, listening, adapting to change

Materials: Open space and optional music.

Setup: Choose a familiar game such as walking, jumping, dancing or follow-the-leader.

Activity: Begin with one simple rule, such as "When the music plays, we dance." Then introduce playful rule changes: "Now when the music plays, we freeze," or "Now we dance slowly," or "Now we move like tiny robots." Keep the tone light and funny. This helps children practise coping with unexpected changes without feeling like they have made a mistake.



Weekly Planner



HULA HOOP ACTIVITIES

MYSTERY BOX BUILD

Skill focus: Creativity, problem-solving, tolerance of uncertainty, collaborative play

Materials: A box or basket of random loose parts, such as cardboard tubes, fabric scraps, blocks, pegs, lids, boxes, sticks, tape or recycled materials.

Setup: Place the materials inside a covered box so children cannot see everything at first.

Activity: Children take turns pulling one item from the mystery box and adding it to a shared creation. They might build a creature, machine, house, bridge or garden. No one knows what the final creation will become, which helps children practise building a plan as they go instead of needing everything decided from the beginning.



SURPRISE STORY PATH

Skill focus: Imagination, sequencing, language, emotional flexibility

Materials: Picture cards, small toys, animal figures or story stones.

Setup: Place several story items face down or inside a basket.

Activity: Begin a simple story, then let each child choose a mystery card or object to decide what happens next. For example, "The bear was walking through the forest when suddenly..." and the child reveals a boat, a dragon, a rainbow or a sandwich. The group adds the new idea into the story. This helps children practise unexpected changes in a playful, imaginative way.



ALMOST WRONG OBSTACLES

Skill focus: Motor planning, flexible thinking, problem-solving, resilience

Materials: Hoops, cushions, cones, stepping stones, tunnels or masking tape.

Setup: Create a simple obstacle course, then tell the children that sometimes the course will change in a silly way.

Activity: Children move through the course, but the educator occasionally adds a playful surprise: "Oh no, the river moved!" and shifts a hoop slightly, or "The bridge is sleepy now, crawl under it instead." The changes should be small and manageable, not overwhelming. This helps children practise adjusting their plan, laughing when something changes, and discovering that uncertainty can be safe.



Daily play options

A large, empty square box with a black border, intended for a drawing or written response.

This or That

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